

Saturday Morning Was Not Optional

Robert J. Lammert

Essay

June 13, 2026

A nostalgic reminder that a little waiting, a little friction, and a little shared inconvenience once taught us how to be human.

Copyright ©2026 Robert J. Lammert, All Rights Reserved

Saturday Morning Was Not Optional

There are few things in modern parenting more humbling than watching your child wake up on a Saturday morning, look at a world containing nearly every cartoon ever made, every movie ever filmed, every season of every show, plus a YouTube video of a man opening a box inside another box for reasons no historian will ever fully understand, and then say, “There’s nothing to watch.”

Nothing.

Not one thing.

A thousand streaming services. A Roku remote. Search functions. Profiles. Recommendations. Continue Watching. Because You Watched. Trending Now. New Releases. Some algorithm somewhere has dedicated its little robot life to figuring out what this child might enjoy, and still the answer is boredom.

Meanwhile, when I was a kid, Saturday morning was not a casual entertainment option. It was an appointment.

You did not wake up slowly. You did not stretch, check your phone, consider your mood, and then ease into the day like a retired yacht owner. You got up. You moved. You had a schedule to keep.

My brothers and I knew this in our bones. Saturday morning cartoons were not simply “available.” They appeared. Like a comet. Like a presidential motorcade. Like something you had to respect because it would not be back just because you had poor time management.

Seven o’clock meant something. If your favorite cartoon came on at 7:30, you needed to be in position by 7:27 at the latest, preferably with cereal already poured and your body arranged on the carpet in whatever spinally irresponsible position seemed comfortable at the time. There was no pause button. There was no “rewind that part.” There was no “hang on, I have to go to the bathroom.” Your bladder had to negotiate with network television, and network television did not care.

That was the deal.

If you missed the theme song, you missed the theme song. If your little brother walked in front of the TV during the best part, that image was gone forever, replaced only by resentment and possibly a shove that would later be described to Mom in competing sworn statements.

This sounds primitive now, like I am describing entertainment by candlelight while churning butter, but it really was not that long ago. It was just a different relationship with time.

I remember coming home on the bus when I was younger, knowing that G.I. Joe came on at 3:30 and He-Man at 4:00. Those times were fixed in my head with more seriousness than most state capitals. The bus ride home had stakes. If the weather was bad, if the bus was late, if some kid forgot his backpack and we had to wait while he slowly realized that actions have consequences, I could feel the clock ticking.

Every stop mattered.

Every delay was an attack on justice.

If I missed the episode, that was it. Gone. I did not get to see it later that night. I did not get to search it. I did not get to ask the television to start over. Maybe I would catch it someday in reruns. Maybe not. Childhood had

a way of teaching acceptance through badly timed snowstorms and the rigid programming decisions of local affiliates.

To be fair, this was not always noble character formation. Sometimes it was just annoying. Missing an episode of G.I. Joe because the bus driver had to creep through slush at the speed of a nervous turtle did not make me wise. It made me irritated and dramatic, which, in true Rob fashion, probably means it did prepare me for adulthood after all.

But there was something in it.

There was an understanding that the world did not automatically rearrange itself around your preference. Things came and went. You could catch them or miss them. You could plan ahead or you could suffer the consequences, which in this case meant not knowing whether Duke escaped the trap until your friend told you on Monday in a version that was almost certainly inaccurate.

Entertainment had scarcity. Not real scarcity, of course. We are not talking about bread lines here. We are talking about cartoons, movies, and the emotional devastation of missing a toy commercial dressed up as a plot. So yes, perspective matters.

But even small scarcity teaches something.

It teaches anticipation. It teaches patience. It teaches compromise. It teaches the strange, low-grade grief of wanting something and not getting it immediately, which is a sensation modern life has tried very hard to eliminate, mostly by handing us a remote and saying, "Here, press this until your soul gives up."

And look, I'm with you. Some of this is fantastic. I do not want to go back to adjusting rabbit ears on top of the television while someone yells, "Go back! It was better before!" from the couch like a tiny unpaid broadcast engineer. I do not miss tracking on a VCR. I do not miss returning a movie late and feeling like I had personally betrayed the civic order.

Convenience is convenient. That is how they get you.

But there is a difference between making life easier and making every desire feel urgent.

My kids have grown up in a world where entertainment waits for them. They do not have to wait for entertainment. That sounds like a small difference, but I am not sure it is. When the show is always ready, when the movie can always be restarted, when the song can always be skipped, when the funny part can always be replayed, something changes in the way you relate to the thing itself.

It becomes less of an event and more of a resource.

Saturday morning used to have shape. It had a beginning and an end. It had cereal, commercials, pajamas, arguments over volume, and the grim realization that eventually the cartoons would turn into bowling, fishing, golf, or some other adult programming that felt like punishment for being alive after 11:00 a.m.

You did not choose from everything. You chose from what was on.

That limitation was part of the ritual. You watched shows you loved, shows you tolerated, and shows you only watched because they were wedged between two better shows and changing the channel required standing up, which was asking a lot from a child full of cereal and destiny.

Now Saturday morning is just morning. The cartoons are still there, technically. More than there. An impossible number of them. But the ritual is gone because there is no deadline. There is no shared moment. There is no sense that if you are not in front of the TV right now, you missed it.

My kids hardly get out of bed for it.

And why would they? Their shows will still be there at 9:00. And noon. And Tuesday. And next year. They can watch three minutes, pause it, leave, come back, rewind, skip, switch apps, switch shows, switch moods, and then complain that the Wi-Fi is slow, which is the modern version of crossing the plains in a covered wagon.

I know how this sounds. This is dangerously close to old-man territory. “Back in my day, we had three channels and we were grateful.” Next thing you know I will be defending lead paint because it built character.

That is not what I mean.

I am not arguing that inconvenience is automatically virtue. Some things were worse. A lot of things were worse. There was nothing spiritually superior about missing the end of a movie because the VHS tape had been recorded over by a weather report and half an episode of Matlock. That was not character building. That was domestic terrorism with a VCR.

And yes, I love being able to pause a movie. I am middle-aged. Pausing is now a basic human right. Any society that makes a man choose between bladder dignity and plot continuity has lost its way.

But I do wonder what happens when children rarely have to wait for ordinary things.

Because waiting is not just empty space. Waiting gives shape to wanting. It makes you decide whether you actually care. It creates anticipation, and anticipation does something that instant access cannot. It stretches the experience out. It gives it weight.

You went to the local video rental store, whether it was Blockbuster Video, Hollywood Video, or one of those local places with sun-faded posters in the window and a clerk who seemed to know too much about both cinema and your family’s late fees. You walked the aisles. You looked at the box covers. The actual boxes were usually empty, of course, because civilization required a system of plastic decoys. Behind the counter or tucked behind the display case was the real treasure, assuming someone else had not already rented it.

As kids, we would scan those shelves like we were making decisions of national importance. Action. Comedy. New Releases. Family. The mysterious aisle you were not supposed to spend too much time in because Mom had eyes in the back of her head and possibly a radar system. We would bring our candidates to her and begin the negotiations.

Can we get this one?

No.

Why not?

Because I said no.

No.

Maybe.

“Maybe” was hope. “Maybe” meant the legal team had entered the room.

And when you were done, you had one sacred commandment.

Be Kind, Rewind.

That little sticker was moral instruction in four words. It said, “Other people exist.” It said, “You are not the last person in the world.” It said, “Do not make the next family sit down with snacks only to discover they are starting at the end credits because you were raised by wolves.”

That was part of the system.

Again, not a tragedy. Nobody needs to hold a candlelight vigil for the lost ethics of VHS returns.

Small habits become assumptions. Assumptions become expectations. Expectations become the way we treat the world.

If everything is available immediately, it gets easier to believe everything should be available immediately. If every inconvenience can be solved by a button, it gets harder to tolerate the inconveniences that cannot. If every desire is treated like a customer service ticket, we start to lose the ability to sit with wanting, disappointment, boredom, and delay.

And at the end of the day, life is full of delay.

People do not become who we want them to be on demand. Forgiveness does not happen on demand. Trust does not rebuild on demand. Maturity does not download while you sleep because the Wi-Fi was strong. A family does not become close because everyone has access to the same content. A kid does not learn patience because a streaming service asked whether they wanted to skip the recap.

Some things take time because they are human.

That is where the moral center of this little complaint lives, somewhere between G.I. Joe at 3:30 and a Roku remote with too many buttons. I am not mad that my kids have more choices. I am not mad that they can watch what they want when they want. Honestly, good for them. I would have lost my mind if eight-year-old me could have summoned He-Man at will. I would probably still be sitting there, surrounded by cereal bowls, asking for just one more episode.

What worries me is not the convenience itself. It is the training.

The world keeps teaching kids that friction is failure. That waiting is unnecessary. That boredom is an emergency. That every preference deserves a menu, every discomfort deserves a workaround, and every moment should be optimized until there is no room left for anticipation, patience, or shared inconvenience.

But shared inconvenience is where a lot of life happens.

It happened on the carpet on Saturday mornings. It happened in the back seat on the way to the video store. It happened while walking aisles with your brothers, arguing over movie boxes, lobbying Mom like tiny entertainment attorneys. It happened when the bus was late and the cartoon was missed and there was nothing to do but be annoyed and move on.

That last part matters.

Be annoyed and move on.

That is not a bad skill. It might be one of the better ones. The ability to miss something without collapsing. The ability to wait without treating waiting as an injustice. The ability to choose from what is available instead of resenting the universe for not offering everything.

I do not want my kids to grow up deprived of convenience just so they can appreciate my childhood. That would be ridiculous. Also, they would revolt. I am not looking to recreate 1989 in my living room as some kind of parental historical reenactment, complete with a VCR, a wood-paneled television, and me yelling, “Don’t touch that dial,” while everyone slowly loses what little respect they still have for me.

But I do want them to know that not everything good arrives instantly.

I want them to know that anticipation can be part of joy. That choosing together matters. That shared rituals are different from shared accounts. That sometimes the limits around a thing make the thing more meaningful. That not every inconvenience is an enemy.

And maybe, now and then, I want them out of bed on a Saturday morning before the day has already given up.

Not because the cartoons will disappear.

Because childhood does.